

A full-page photograph of a young woman with short dark hair, wearing a white tank top and grey shorts, standing in a living room. She is barefoot and has her hand near her mouth. Sunlight streams in from the right, casting long shadows across the carpet. In the background, there is a brown couch, a coffee table with a water bottle and papers, and a kitchen area with a refrigerator and various bottles on the counter.

My ROOMMATE TOOK *Izzy*

A stolen girlfriend story

EVAN SLATE

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My roommate came home late from work, slammed the door and stomped around and woke me up again. But that was Cameron, you had to learn to live with him. I felt Izzy stir too, he woke her up as well.

I tried to get back to sleep, but I could hear every little thing, the kitchen tap, the glass of water on the counter, the fridge opening and closing. I heard him grumble about nothing to eat and rolled my eyes at the ceiling because I knew it meant he'd get into my stuff again.

Izzy rolled half over and patted my cheek and shrugged at me with empathetic eyes. "He always comes home hungry," she whispered nearly inaudibly to me and she smiled and kissed me lightly and warm.

I took a breath and tried again to get back to sleep. I was just about there when I heard his door open again. Here came his heavy stomps one more time, now straight across the unit and right to my door.

He opened it without knocking and came inside. He tugged at Izzy's hand saying nothing to her or me. He took her with him back to his room, and shut his door, now with her inside.

I was only up as far as my elbows, blinking and staring into the impression her body left in my bed, still warm from how we slept spooned together, my arms around her from behind.

"Hey..." I said to the open door and I chuckled, too, the whole thing being startlingly absurd. Did he need to talk to her again? It was, I checked with straining eyes, 12:15 AM. Was he out of it somehow? Drunk? But he'd been at work, he told me about the extra time they were all putting in. I searched my mind looking for a reason for him to do what he just did. Was I forgetting something he'd said or something Izzy mentioned?

His room was on the other side of the apartment from my room, the place being virtually a mirror image split down the middle. Did he have a brain seizure and go the wrong way? No, because he went back to the right room, he just took my girlfriend with him.

Fully awake now, I got up, pulled on some shorts and a t-shirt, and carefully opened my door to peer out. He didn't bring her to the living room or the kitchen, these were still dark as night. I crept on tiptoes through the place and down into the short hallway where his door was.

There was light coming out from under it. Closer to it now in the dead of night, I could hear light music. But there was a vocal track not keeping time or in key with the rest of it, a high-pitched, rhythmically repeating breathy cry.

It stopped and the music alone carried on more cleanly before I heard what I distinctly recognized as Izzy's high and light girlish laughter.

I dropped my jaw wide open, pressed my palms into my temples, and sank against the wall outside his closed door. I glared at the floor tracking left and right. How could a person just do that? How could a person just come in and grab someone's girlfriend and take her to his room?

My reeling mind was seized by the grunt I heard through the door. It was Izzy again, and I heard her voice clearly and distinctly this time, too: "Fuck...!"

I sank down against the wall into a squat with my hands cupped around my eyes, trying to make the whole previous five minutes disappear from my world.

But I was mesmerized by the sounds Izzy made too, by the sounds she and my roommate made, and I was transported into a paralyzed trance. My eyes dried, I stared at the floor so hard. My knees swelled with the pressure of squatting against the wall. Izzy's voice went higher, then stopped, and she laughed again, but then she grunted too and her cries came higher yet.

They weren't talking this time, that much was obvious. I knew something was up between them. I was not completely shocked at what I heard through the door. "Just talking" was what both of them had been telling me they were doing, those times I came home from getting groceries or something, and ran into Izzy just leaving his room and shutting his door behind her, or him just leaving mine, her still inside, him shutting the door on her.

Izzy was "just being super nice" to him lately, helping him through something she told me I shouldn't ask about, that he'd tell me when he was ready. She was like that naturally, a born therapist. He told her that.

"Just talking," he called it, and he apparently covered his feelings by laughing about it, slapping my shoulder, making a joke about getting in

touch with his feelings, “getting real.”

Izzy would, at those moments, look at me with a knowing expression.

I didn’t notice when all the sounds inside his room stopped entirely. I was still circling the drain outside his door, when footsteps from inside approached.

My heart pounded as though I should be the one to fear being caught secretly listening. I sprang up, my knees nearly giving out and shooting pain up my spine, and I dashed high on my toes speeding stealthily through the apartment and back into my room where I slid at speed into bed and yanked the sheets up around me. And just in time, too.

With my heart pounding three beats a second, I pretended I had remained sleeping the whole time when my door was slowly pushed open and shut again. Izzy quietly came back to bed, taking a moment to pull her sleep shorts and tank top back on, it sounded like. She settled in as carefully as possible trying not to wake me, resuming her exact position before she was taken away by Cameron.

I faced the wall with my eyes wide open, scanning around the blackness of it like a lizard, my heart beating too hard.

But in the way these things go, my mind began losing grip on what I was so wildly confused about, and I felt it physically in my body when sleep crept up on me and overtook me all over again. You wouldn’t think a person could sleep after something like that. But I could. We all would.

In the morning, we woke up together like we often did, stretching and kissing and laughing at ourselves struggling to get up and out. It took me several minutes of dim wakefulness to remember that anything at all happened during the night. There was certainly no sign from Izzy that she was going to acknowledge it. She looked like she didn’t even remember it herself, which of course had to be an impossibility, thinking back.

We came out into the kitchen one after the other, her heading for the coffee maker, me pulling open the living room curtains and plopping down on the couch, scratching myself and yawning. She didn’t have to ask how to make my coffee, she’d slept over enough times to know. It was, aside from the shocking incident in the middle of the night, a perfect morning in a perfect relationship. It was in fact the first one for me that made me think about the long term.

She came in and tussled my hair and kissed the back of my neck and handed me my mug. Then she got down on the floor under the beams of

morning sunshine to do some of her morning yoga that she was always trying to cajole me into joining her with.

We otherwise chatted about how we slept, things coming up for the day, her family issues, all the usual things, as she pulled herself into contortions in front of me.

I replied and sipped and sank into the couch, but not without the image of her being taken from my bed, and then of squatting outside his door hearing what I heard, and then, shame-filled and fearful of getting caught, dashing back to my bed.

I watched Izzy get down and stretch in front of me and laugh that light lilting laugh of hers because it was a provocative pose in front of my feet, but my mind was filled with darker visions of me leaping up and pulling her hand out of Cameron's hand, slapping him as though he were in a trance, or punching him out cold.

Izzy squatted and pushed her open palm up to the ceiling, but I saw visions of shaking sleep from my head and marching across the apartment, charging through Cameron's door, and taking Izzy by the hand right back to my bed, and locking my door, too. Maybe punching Cameron in the face in the process.

She looked up at me with sparking eyes as she shifted position and grinned because this new pose was even more provocative than the others, and I smiled back down at her, drew my eyes over her body, and sipped my coffee.

In my mind, I was yelling at her, shaking her by her shoulders, demanding to know how she could let that happen to her. What were you thinking? How could you go with him like that? Why would you let him take you?

But she came up off the floor, leaned her palms into the top of the couch behind me down either side of my head, and slowly pushed her knee up between my legs. She came down so slow, so warmly, that I had to lean my head back to look up into her eyes where her face hovered over mine by two inches.

She liked to tease me like this, and this morning was no different. She put on her sexualized face, her eyes half lidded, her mouth parted, her lips loose, her breath halting and guttural, until, working me up into a spinning state, she brushed her soft lips against mine, barely touched the tip of her poking tongue to my lip. She said, in a put-on Hollywood harlot voice,

“Bacon and eggs, sourdough toast, and cubed potatoes, uhh!” and she laughed out loud in my face, tapped my chin with her hand to close my mouth, and skipped, pleased with herself, laughing and darting her gaze over her shoulder at me, back to the kitchen to get that breakfast going.

I had to continually remind myself we had a huge thing to talk about.

But Cameron stirred and we both heard him cough and groan and a minute later his door opened and he came out scratching and pushing his hair around his head.

I stiffened on the couch. I almost forgot about him, Izzy had distracted me so much. But it wasn't just a big talk her and I had looming, but me and Cameron needed to have an even bigger talk. I mean, who even does that? what he did.

Izzy shot a glance at me when Cameron came into the kitchen with her. I scrolled on my phone through the news headlines. But in the corner of my eyes, I could see Cameron step up behind Izzy where she moved bacon around the pan. He put his hand on her lower back, down lower over the flare of her ass, and leaned his face into her hair, still bed-messy. He reached into the pan and she lightly tapped his fingers with her spatula.

“Wait for it!” she said in an exasperated tone, but an amused one too.

He smirked and tapped her ass, which she didn't react to at all. Cameron was always physical with her like that, tapping her here and there, tugging her hair playfully. “It's just the way men like him communicate,” Izzy explained to me, rolling her eyes and shaking her head. He's just a big baby.”

“Well I don't like it,” I said to her in bed the previous weekend.

“I'll tell him to stop it in front of you.”

“It's not just because he does it in front of me,” I said.

She rolled her body on top of mine, pushed my hair from my face, and kissed me. “Poopsy,” she said. “We're just friends.”

But things had been building for weeks and I was getting increasingly bothered by all of it, when you added it all up. They laughed together in the kitchen, giving hip-checks to each other. He pulled her hair when she was doing her yoga in front of him or even on the couch where he was stretched out watching a game, her laughing about it, distracting him like that.

When Izzy first started sleeping over, she was careful about what she wore leaving my bedroom, getting fully dressed, even if Cameron wasn't home.

“He could come home!” she would say to me and shake her eyes like I didn’t understand the risks.

But lately, she was sauntering around in low hip-riding shorts she slept in, loose overstretched tank tops, her hair all bed-messy. She said she was only trying to get him to do yoga too, like me, when I told her she was probably bugging him doing it on the floor in front of him or on the couch beside him.

Lately she cuddled with him and even pulled a blanket up over them both when we were chilling at night watching shows. She kept saying it was just fun, that I needed to relax. “It’s just Cameron!” like that should allay my concerns.

Cameron slid his hand down inside the back of her shorts where she took the bacon off the stove. She held the hot grease-coated spatula up to his face and glanced over at me. I looked away, not wanting to be caught staring. “I am warning you Mr. Cameron Jacks,” she said in a low, private, and threatening voice.

I ducked my face deeper into my phone, but I could see out the corner of my eyes. He only smirked close to her face and squeezed her ass with his hand under her shorts. She didn’t stop him, she only held his gaze with hers.

“Come get breaky!” she called to me even before she moved her eyes from his. She was smirking at him just as much as he was at her.

I came to the stool at the counter. Cameron remained on the kitchen side standing while he ate from the plate Izzy put out for him.

“Saturday,” Cameron said. “Don’t you have that fix the world thing you do Saturdays?”

He thought I couldn’t tell his hand was behind Izzy, rubbing her back up and down.

“You mean that creek enhancement thing?” I said with a smirk. How many times had I explained it to him? “It’s good exercise, get out in nature, doing something good for the Earth.”

“I think you should go with him,” Izzy said, half turning to him and grinning up one side of her face. “Do a bad man like you some good,” she laughed before she absently dabbed a spot of butter from the corner of his mouth with her pinky, and sucked it off her finger.

He spread his feet on the floor and hunched his shoulders over to start into his breakfast with vigor, wrapping his fists around his knife and fork.

“You have no manners,” Izzy said, and she looked at me. “Your roommate has absolutely no table manners.”

He stuffed his mouth with too much egg and toast and turned to her chewing so large, she recoiled as though afraid she’d get sprayed with his food. He leaned in as though he was going to kiss her with his mouth full, and she screamed and turned away, shielding her face and laughing.

“You should come out with me, Iz,” I said.

“Oh, babe, I would, but I can’t. I brought my work over, I need to do a bunch of stuff before Monday.”

“You’re just going to hang out here while I’m gone?”

“That’s okay, isn’t it?” she said, still ducking and swaying at her waist away from Cameron. She pushed her hand into his chest to keep him at bay.

“Of course,” I said. “No problem.” I liked her spending more time at my place. I liked getting more domestic with her. It made me feel like we were getting closer to the next step, getting closer to her moving in. She already had a toothbrush, make-up, and an increasing amount of clothes in my drawers and closet. There was a lot more make-up lately, and she wore a lot more too.

But Cameron was really needing that talk. He took his plate and utensils to the sink, but Izzy turned and rested her hand on his lower back. “I got this, you don’t know what you’re doing, go relax on the couch.”

He turned to her and just like that, kissed her on the lips.

Both of them turned to me as though it was an accident, something that slipped out between them. But I was already looking away like I didn’t see it. I was not ready for the conversation that was required. I couldn’t say anything about the kiss, not with last night still looming and unaddressed. But I was getting increasingly pissed off about everything.

“What you got on today?” I said to Cameron when he came around the counter and pushed his t-shirt all the way up to his chin to rub his hand over his bared stomach and chest. He pulled his top off entirely and draped it over the back of a chair, which I detested. But you pick your mountains, don’t you.

He fell into the couch and spread his knees and slumped down so deep only his head was propped up against the back cushions.

“A big fat day of doing nothing,” he said. “Fucking work, bro, they’re killing me.”

“Poor thing,” Izzy said from the kitchen and she chuckled. She disappeared into my room.

I spun around on the stool and leaned back against the counter behind me propping my elbows up and back on it.

“I heard you come in last night after 12,” I said.

“I didn’t wake you up, did I?” he said, looking over at me with genuine concern.

“You woke Izzy up,” I said, and I instantly regretted it. I don’t know where that came from. I was nowhere near ready for the big conversation.

“She’s a light sleeper,” he said, looking back down at his own belly button he seemed to be cleaning with his pinky, examining it for lint.

I shook my head privately at him, the way he so casually mentioned something as intimate as how light a sleeper Izzy is. Now he cleaned his ear with the same pinky.

“How do you know that about Izzy?” My heart was pounding and my ears fluttered inside with the pressure.

He looked up at me with casual confusion. “Huh?” he said, before examining his pinky for earwax, and plunging it back in again.

“Light sleeper,” I said.

“Fucking chick fell asleep in my room last night,” he said and he chuckled and pulled up his legs to stretch out along the length of the couch facing me with his head propped on his arm behind him up against the arm of the couch.

I swallowed so hard it felt like I was downing a baseball. “She fell asleep in your room?”

“We were just talking again, she was going over things with me, you were asleep,” he said. “She came inside to make sure we didn’t wake you up, hope that’s okay, bro.”

“She went to your room last night?”

“Just for a bit, you know, talk about shit, and then next thing I know I’m rocking her and pushing her and snapping my fingers in front of her face, she was sound asleep!” He laughed out loud. “Bed isn’t big enough, bruh! I made her go back to your bed when she was done.”

I dropped my jaw open and rubbed my cheeks with fingers and thumb watching him as he looked over his nails.

“She was in your bed?”

He snorted. "It's just how we talk," he said and he shrugged. "You know that."

"No, I don't know if I knew that."

He looked at me like I was having him on. "Well you know we talk a lot, you know there's no chair in my room, where do you think we're talking?"

Izzy came out at that point now dressed in white denim shorts and light off-the-shoulder sweater, carrying her laptop under her arm. She went to the couch and kicked Cameron's foot. "Shove over," she said.

Cameron lifted his legs and she sat down and made ready to receive his legs back down over her lap. She placed her laptop on top of his shins and opened it, pulling her own bare feet up to the coffee table in front of her.

"Izzy," I said.

She turned to me after finishing the sentence she was reading, her face slowly turning, her eyes still reading. "Mm?"

"So you fell asleep in Cameron's room last night?"

She spun quickly to Cameron on her other side. "What did you tell him?" she said with a spreading grin.

Cameron shrugged, now looking at his phone in front of his face. "That you came over to talk and you fell asleep."

She stared at him a few more seconds before she turned back to me. "Did we wake you up?"

Now it was my turn to stare down the ticking seconds. "Maybe a bit, I think so, yeah, I don't remember."

"Sorry if we were talking too loud. Cameron closed his door and put some music on so you wouldn't hear."

I swallowed hard again, that baseball in my throat coming back up. "It's just, you fell asleep in his bed, he said."

She spun back to him with bulging eyes, a wider grin.

He remained as casual and unconcerned as before. "Where you gonna sit? I guess you could have sat on the edge of the bed." He half lifted his head from his arm bent under it. "I meant to say she sat on the edge of my bed." He shrugged at her. "What? He knows I don't have a chair."

"I was just so tired!" she said to me over her shoulder.

"I bore her," Cameron said with a chuckle and she gasped at him and slapped his bare chest.

“I told him to be quiet,” she said to me. “The way you stomp around and slam things in the kitchen, you don’t even try,” she said now back to him again.

He brought his foot up and placed it against her shoulder and rocked her where she sat. “You’re the one that needs to be quiet,” he said, and he smirked and snorted.

“Well maybe you guys shouldn’t be talking late at night anyway,” I said.

She slapped his leg. “What I told him exactly when he dragged me out of your bed last night.”

“I hardly dragged you,” he said privately. “I didn’t drag her, I invited her,” he said to me.

“I just don’t think anything can be so pressing and important you have to talk about right then and there at like 1 in the morning.”

“You’re right,” she said with a sharp nod. “He’s right,” she said to Cameron with a grin.

“We’ll talk today out here when you’re out dragging the river for shopping carts,” he said.

“It’s a creek, and it’s not just shopping carts.” I went through the kitchen, poured my remaining coffee out and went to my room to change.

A moment later Izzy came in after me and shut the door. “You seem upset, are you upset? I can tell you are.”

I kept my back to her longer as I made like I was uncertain what t-shirt to wear to the creek clean up.

She came up to me and ran her hand around my waist. “I know you are, Cameron says I’m a natural therapist.”

I turned around and whipped off my top and stretched the fresh t-shirt down and on. She stepped back to give me room. “I told you already I’m uncomfortable with you guys talking all the time, touching each other all the time. He was grabbing your ass this morning, for one small example.”

She shrugged and grinned. “He’s fun, you know that. He pushes you around too, he teases you just as much!”

“It’s hardly the same thing,” I said.

She sat down on the edge of my bed and patted it beside her.

I sat down.

“Tell me what’s really the matter.”

“It feels like there’s something going on between you two, I gotta be honest with you, Izzy.”

“Something like what? Tell me what you feel.”

I swallowed hard, hardly able to say it. “The way you let him grab you. And he even kissed you this morning right on the lips. Then you’re all over his chest on the couch and he’s all down your ass in the kitchen. I can see you know!”

“I know you can see,” she said shaking her head at me.

“I can hear too,” I added.

She kissed me lightly on the lips and put her arm around my neck.

“Okay, so I want to confess something to you now.”

I looked sideways and up to her.

“But if you tell Cameron I told you this, I will kill you!” she said and she put her finger to her lips and went “shh!” and grinned.

“Imagine if you came over to my place, and say I had a roommate, and say she was this super cute girl you couldn’t take your eyes off of.”

“What? No, I would never...”

She put her finger and thumb to my lips, closed them and shook her head. “You’re just listening. But it’s okay, babe, I’m not threatened by you noticing a super cute girl, it’s totally normal. But say I had a roommate like that, and every time you stayed over, she was flirting with you, and saying things to you like how good you look, do you work out, stuff like that, and imagine she keeps finding ways to touch you and bump into you.”

“That wouldn’t happen.”

“Just say it did. For argument’s sake.”

I took a deep breath, shut my eyes, put myself in the space she was asking me to, and shook out my arms. “Okay, fine.”

“Now let’s say you flirt back a bit, but it’s just flirting, it’s not for real.”

“You know I would never do that.”

“I know that about you. But just say you’re weaker than that, just say you can’t really help it, it’s too much to overcome. I know you would never do it, but if you were me, like, maybe not so strong like you are.” She squeezed my bicep and raised her eyebrows at me.

“What are you saying?”

“I’m saying that if a person flirts a little and the other person flirts back, it hardly means that they’re going to leave the person and go be with the other person. Especially if the other person is a complete idiot who can’t even rinse a plate off or keep food in a fridge.” She kissed my nose.

“Baby, I have zero, less than zero, I have negative 200 interest in Cameron that way. I could not possibly live with him.” She rolled her face back to the ceiling. “Ugh! I can hardly imagine it. The way he leaves his clothes all over the floor and the furniture, and he never makes his bed! I swear to god I’m going to have to start washing his sheets!”

She looked at me with bulging eyes and then tussled my hair. “You’re my kind of man, Dave. You care about things, you look after things, you can do laundry and cook, you can fix things, you’re a handyman!”

She leaned over in front of my face and looked up into my eyes and kissed me lightly on the lips. “You’re like Minneapolis, hard-working, honest, saving money, a solid guy, and I can’t wait to bring you home to show you off, and the only reason I haven’t yet is because it’s scary how serious I am feeling about you, if you haven’t already been able to tell.”

“Well I feel pretty serious about you too, Izzy,” I said.

“And Cameron, he’s Las Vegas. Like totally, flat out Las Vegas!” she shoved her hand out across my room. “He is strictly the 3 days, 2 nights excursion, in and out, leave no trace, do not pass go, do not collect 200 kind of man,” she said. Then she laughed and plugged her nose to stop. “Can you imagine me bringing Cameron home to meet mom and dad?” She threw her head back. “Oh my god, they would write me out of their will, he’s nothing but bundles of muscle and all take, take, take!” she laughed. “He’s very rude, you see that yourself, the way he just grabbed me last night!”

“I was awake.”

“So you know! You saw him just barge in here, just tear me out of my boyfriend’s loving arms! How could I be with a man like that?” she shook her head again.

“So you’re not interested in him that way at all,” I said.

She shrugged. “It’s like the pretty girl I have for a roommate. Wouldn’t you try to kiss her if I wasn’t home, if I couldn’t see?”

“Of course not.”

She shrugged. “He’s just a little Las Vegas, I know you know what I mean. Thrilling to visit, but you could never live there.”

“So even though he’s sticking his hand down the back of your shorts and kissing you in front of me, even though he’s bringing you to his room and you’re falling asleep on his bed, I’m supposed to just look the other way?”

“I come over here to be with you. It’s not me who let him move in on the other side of the suite.” She kissed my nose. “You moved him in, you own the lease, you see what I mean? You’re the kind of guy who can sign a lease, who can make sure rent is paid, who stocks the fridge and empties the dishwasher. But he’s the kind of guy who no one would rent to, you can barely rely on him for rent, he can’t even rinse a plate let alone put it in the dishwasher.”

“So why are you interested in him at all? Why do I keep finding you coming out of his room when I get home, or find him coming out of my room with you in there?”

“Would you rather your girlfriend hates your roommate? Imagine how that would be,” she said and she widened her eyes and nodded at me. “Isn’t it better that they get along so well, your roommate and your girlfriend?”

“It’s good, yeah,” I said. “I guess.”

“So go do your creek thing and I’ll talk to Cameron about grabbing me and pushing me around and manhandling me the way he does. You know what?”

I looked at her. “What?”

“I’m actually so glad you brought this up. Because I’ve been trying to warn him about it, and now that you’re saying it too, it lets my really put the man in his place. He should not be grabbing me and pinning me up against the wall and grabbing my tits and ass and trying to make me take my clothes off.”

“He does that to you?”

She rolled her eyes. “That’s not the half of it! He keeps trying to hold me down, he keeps trying to shove his thing at me. Did you know he pulls his shorts down and waves it at me?”

“No I didn’t know that.”

“Well he does.”

“What else does he do?”

“I’m not going to torture you with details.”

“No really, tell me, I think I should know.”

“Promise you won’t tell him I said?”

“I promise.”

“You’re going to be mad though, I can tell.”

“I won’t be mad.”

“No,” she said, “you’re right, I know that about you.” She sighed. “I feel like I can tell you anything and you won’t ever get mad.”

“Of course not,” I said.

“No, of course not.”

“So tell me then. I need to know.”

“I’m never going to tell you everything!” She pushed me away from her playfully.

“Tell me one thing.”

“You don’t want to know, trust me.”

“I want to know, I promise you.”

“If I tell you, promise me you won’t think about it all the time, or bring it up again, or use it against me.”

“It sounds serious, Iz.”

“It’s not that much really. It’s hardly even considered that bad by most people probably.”

“Just tell me, Izzy. I have to get going.”

She stared at me, her eyes bouncing back and forth between my eyes. “It’s not even considered sex by most people,” she finally said with a tiny, nervous grin.

“Just tell me.” I patted her back, rubbed her.

She leaned into me with her shoulder to my chest and rubbed her head against my shoulder. “What if you take it the wrong way though?”

“I won’t.”

“Promise?”

“Promise.”

She took a deep breath and let out a long sigh. “What if I told you it was that thing I don’t exactly do with you? Because I said I don’t like it. Because I find it demeaning.”

“I’m still not sure what you’re talking about, Iz.”

She clenched her jaw then lifted her head from my shoulder and twisted her face to look into mine closely. “Okay. Ready? He makes me suck his dick,” she said and she pursed her grin and covered her mouth with her cupped hand.

“He makes you?” I said.

“Well he doesn’t make me-make me,” she rolled her eyes. “But he asks me to.”

“He just asks you that, like flat out?”

“It’s not quite like that. You know how he is. I told you already, he’s the kind of guy who communicates physically. But you can just tell what he’s thinking.” She shrugged.

“I’m not following, Izzy.”

“So like when I go to his room, right?”

“To talk.”

“Right, to talk. And then he’ll pull his sheets back and of course his thing is hanging out just laying there.” She rolled her eyes.

“I can’t believe I’m hearing this.”

“And he just kind of pulls my hair and stuff and then he pushes my head down.”

“For fuck sakes, Izzy!”

“You promised you would just listen and not get mad.”

I held my hand up and twisted a make-believe key at my mouth.

“So he pushes my head down, and so I kiss it like, but of course that’s not good enough for guys like that, so I lick it even, like all over, and finally he’s like shoving it in my mouth and I’m gagging and trying my best and he starts thrusting into me because it feels good of course, and so I keep going because I’m not going to start for a guy and not finish for him, right?”

I had promised not to react, but inside I was losing my mind. I crossed my arms over my chest. “You told me you hated doing it.”

“And I do hate doing it!” she said, her eyes pleading at mine. “It’s gross, especially when he comes in my mouth. I can’t even swallow it all. It runs out and goes everywhere.”

We both looked down at the same time, but my tenting shorts were impossible to hide. She rubbed me through the fabric. “He makes me rub myself too, when I do it,” she said. “I get like you get too, thinking about it.”

“Stop, Izzy, please.” I shut my eyes.

But she slipped her hand inside my shorts, wrapped it around me. “He rubs me sometimes when I’m doing it for him. He makes me very wet, just like you now.”

“I don’t want to know anymore.”

She pulled her hand out of my pants and stood up, stretching and straightening her clothes. “I’m just going to go check on him, we’ve left him alone a long time. Just come on out when you’re ready, okay?”

She gently opened the door, slipped out, and closed it.

I lay in bed with my arm over my eyes. My chest was rising and falling but it felt like I wasn't getting air. I eventually sat up and hung my head down between my knees. I'd heard the term "information overload," but I'd never experienced what it meant, not until then. It felt like anybody could have told me anything at that point, and I wouldn't have reacted, I couldn't have.

I stood up and wavered and steadied myself. The air in the room felt stale. I flung open my door too hard and stepped out and stood there with my hands on my hips widening my eyes, yawning my jaw, puffing my cheeks out with exhalation.

Izzy and Cameron were sitting on the couch as though discussing something private. Izzy seemed to be patting his thigh to tell him to hang back and she pushed up and came to me. She hung her arms around my neck and ducked her face under mine and looked up. "Hey soldier, you going to live?" She smiled and chuckled.

"Izzy," I said, but my voice hurt my throat.

"So I told Cameron that I told you."

"Why did you do that?"

"He's okay with it, he's fine with it."

I shook my head unable to speak, and I squeezed my fingers against my eyes again.

"Why don't you go do the creek thing, it'll make you feel better, and then we'll see when you get back."

"Are you going to stay here or are you going home?"

"I'm going to stay, I think you know that," she said.

I nodded and made my way to the front door where my shoes were and my creek gear. "We can make dinner together tonight, that'll be nice, won't it," she said.

But I didn't reply, I just went out the door and shut it and locked it behind me.

We finally cleared the blocked culvert that day. We'd been working around it for weeks, but we loosened it finally, dragged a tire on a chain through it, and the release of pressure disgorged a ten-foot long tube of muck, followed by a creek shooting free and clear until the backup, a whole stagnant pond, drained.

It was magnificent, it was glorious. I got home and dropped my bag by the laundry machines.

“Someone’s in a good mood,” Izzy said, slipping out of Cameron’s room like usual.

“It was beautiful,” I said. “We cleared that culvert today.”

Cameron came out of his room a moment later, shutting his door behind him. “What’s that, like a ditch?”

I came into the kitchen. There were tomatoes and herbs spread out over the counter, prosciutto and cheese in packages, a bottle of yeast on the counter I picked up and examined closely. “We making pizza?”

“You’re making it,” Izzy said and she laughed. “Not gonna mess with perfection.”

“You go out to get this stuff?”

“Cameron and I did, after,” she said, and they glanced at each other. “I thought you’d like that.”

I turned to Cameron. “It’s like a tube for a ditch, to go under a road like,” I said to Cameron.

“You mean a sewer,” he said.

“Isn’t a sewer more like a system of pipes?” I said. “This is just a ten foot pipe so the road doesn’t block a creek.”

“Except this one was blocking the creek?” Izzy said.

I got the tomatoes diced and simmering in the pot with oil and herbs and mixed the dough, let it rise in the microwave. “Blocked it as far back as anyone could remember, like probably decades,” I said.

“So you did some very good work today,” she said, and she nearly kissed me on the nose.

“Good work got done all around,” Cameron said, but out the corner of my eye I saw Izzy elbow him in the side and glare at him with peeled eyes.

“I got this,” I said, when she brought the bowl of dough down. Cameron was picking at the prosciutto, dangling tongues of it over his waiting mouth. “Why don’t you guys find a show, I’ll make the pizza.”

“You don’t need any help?” Izzy said with big innocent eyes.

“I do not need any help,” I said and I leaned over and reassured her with a kiss on her cheek. “Go,” I said, and I pointed over the counter at the couch.

Cameron and Izzy sat on the couch. I kneaded the dough and checked my simmering sauce and grated cheese and tore up the prosciutto. I looked up and saw them murmuring to each other, smirking, shoulder checking each other, and tugging the remote back and forth.

“Come when you can,” Izzy called over to me in the kitchen. “Show’s ready.”

“Just play it,” I said. “I can see it from here.”

“You’ll miss it.”

“I can see enough from here, I can hear enough.”

“Play it,” Cameron said.

“It’s so rude, he’s making us our dinner, we could at least wait for the guy.”

“You heard him, he wants us to play.”

“Just go ahead, seriously,” I called over.

“We’re going to turn the light out, is that okay?” Izzy said.

“Whatever,” I called back.

“Wait!” Izzy suddenly shouted. “Pee!” she announced and she laughed.

While she was gone, Cameron sat quietly on the couch staring out the window and I worked quietly in the kitchen, distributing ingredients around the dough.

“You ever wonder what’s going on inside all those apartments out there?” he said blankly.

I lifted my eyes from the counter to the lit up rooms of the buildings all around us, and back down to my pie. “I imagine pretty much the same thing that’s going on in this one.”

I felt his eyes on the top of my dipped head but I didn’t raise my face. I didn’t want to give him the satisfaction. He knew I knew, Izzy told him she told me. We all knew, though nobody said anything.

Izzy came out having changed clothes. “What? More comfy,” she said. She was in her grey cotton drawstring low-hip shorts and white crop-cut tank top and bare feet. I watched as she passed me walking slow and full of motion in her hips. She scrunched up her shoulders and eyes at me and stole a strip of prosciutto.

“The both of you, there’ll be none left for the actual pizza,” I said.

“Come on,” she said privately to me backing up into the other room.

“Live a little, honey!” and she pushed the reset of the strip in her mouth and laughed barely able to keep it in.

She plopped down on the couch. “Blanket,” she ordered Cameron.

“You just changed into that, so now you’re cold?”

“Blanket!” she said more sternly.

He reached over to the shelf under the side table and handed it to her and she flicked it open and spread it out over both of them.

“Too warm.”

“So go change like I did.”

He glanced over at me. I felt his eyes again. He’d grown more uncertain around me lately.

“Go. Change,” Izzy repeated herself.

Cameron left the room and now Izzy and I were quiet and alone.

“You’re going to join us for the show, aren’t you? Or do you have work to do in your room?” she said.

“I plan to stay out here to the bitter end,” I said with a wide smile.

She looked at me a long moment before she said, “Great!”

Cameron came back now in loose shorts and t-shirt only. “Better?” he said to her privately.

“Much better,” she replied just as privately, and she held the blanket up for him to slip under.

“Can you get the lights for us?” she called over to me.

I turned the dimmer down.

“Just all the way off, might as well,” she said, so I bopped the knob with my fist and the room went dark just when the screen came up. They were sitting tight against each other, all four arms and hands hidden under the blanket.

I finished the pizza in the kitchen under the low hanging counter lights and slipped it into the oven and stayed in the kitchen leaning on my elbows down over the counter.

“Are you going to stay over there?” Izzy said.

“Going to stay over here. Blanket’s too small for three.”

She smiled and snorted and turned her face back to the screen. “You’ve got work tomorrow anyway, don’t you?” she said without turning.

“Early to bed, early to rise,” I said. “Walls aren’t going to frame themselves.”

She turned to Cameron. “Can I sleep in your room tonight? You’re not getting up early, are you...?”

Cameron remained fixed on the show. I could tell Izzy poked his side under the blanket.

“No, thank god. Day off tomorrow finally.” He turned to her rolling his head over the cushions behind him. They were both slumped down deep in

the couch. “Not planning on getting out of bed all day,” he said to her.

There followed a silence both among us and in the show, where some intruder in a black ski mask with a silencer gun held up beside his face was readying himself to peer around the corner of a bedroom.

The timer on my phone dinged and I turned around to the oven and pulled on my new oven mitt. The pizza was ready.

I slid it onto a board, rolled the cutter through it four times, and tore off two paper towels. I carried it carefully around the counter and out into the living room. There I inserted myself between the coffee table and the big screen behind me, and set the pizza down, but I rose up to stand again.

“You’re not having any?” Izzy said. Cameron was already folding a piece over and pushing it through his wide-open mouth, Izzy shooting him a pained side eye.

“Enjoy it,” I said privately to her. “I’m just not hungry anymore.”